

Syllabus

Instructors

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Course Description

Climate change communication influences how individuals, organizations, and societies perceive climate change, and how they react to it. In this course, we will discuss research findings in environmental psychology and communication science to understand specific challenges of climate change communication and how to address them.

Learning Objectives

The course will provide students with an overview of current psychological theory and best practices in the area of climate change communication. At the completion of the course, students will be able to:

1. Independently and accurately recognize challenges in climate change communication
2. Clearly describe the psychological mechanisms that influence climate change perceptions and attitudes
3. Critically apply insights from psychology to evaluate the effectiveness of climate change communication
4. Strategically design an effective climate change communication campaign

General Information

- ETH Zurich, room CHN G 42
- Tuesdays 16:15–18:00, weekly, Autumn 2026 (September 15 – December 15, 2026)
- An up-to-date schedule can be found on the [course website](#). This is also where slides and additional materials will be posted.

Participation

[TODO: carried over from 2024 UZH syllabus — rewrite]

Students are expected to actively participate in the course by drawing on their own reading of the materials, as well as their personal experiences and perspectives.

Materials

[TODO: carried over from 2024 UZH syllabus — rewrite. OLAT is the UZH platform, ETH uses Moodle.]

Course plan, reading materials, and slides will be available on OLAT. Please note that no recording will be available for this course.

Assessment

[TODO: carried over from 2024 UZH syllabus — rewrite. Exam date below is from the old course (2024).]

- On-site written exam (3 ECTS) with multiple choice and open questions.
- The exam will take place on 18 December 2024.

Course Structure

Draft

Topics, descriptions, and literature below are carried over from a previous version of this course taught at UZH. Dates are correct for Autumn 2026. Everything else will be revised. Literature is cited as plain text until `references.bib` is populated from Zotero.

#	Date	Topic	Literature
1	15.09.2026	Introduction and organizational questions — Viktoria Cologna & Jan Pfänder Why is climate change communication important and why is it so challenging?	Markowitz & Guckian (2018). Climate change communication: Challenges, insights, and opportunities.
2	22.09.2026	Climate change, the deficit model, and public opinion — Viktoria Cologna What is climate change and how does it occur? Does knowledge-focused communication about climate change lead to more concern and engagement? What is the public opinion about climate change?	Metag et al. (2017). Global warming's five Germanys. Leiserowitz et al. (2024). Climate Change in the American Mind: Beliefs & Attitudes. [TODO: missing from reference list] Shi et al. (2016). Knowledge as a driver of public perceptions about climate change reassessed.
3	29.09.2026	Guest speaker: Dr. Leonard Creutzburg — Invited speaker [TODO: blurb below describes a different person (Dr. Lydia Ebersbach, WWF) — rewrite for the actual speaker] Dr. Lydia Ebersbach is media relations manager at WWF Switzerland. She holds a Magister in History, Politics and Economics from Potsdam University, a PhD in Marketing from St. Gallen University and completed a CAS in Storytelling and Brand Journalism at MAZ / HSL. She will talk to us about the challenges of climate communication from the perspective of a Swiss NGO.	[TODO: framing literature listed here in the template likely belongs to session 4] Lakoff, G. (2010). Why it Matters How We Frame the Environment. Dasandi et al. (2022). Positive, global, and health or environment framing bolsters public support for climate policies. Supran & Oreskes (2021). Rhetoric and frame analysis of ExxonMobil's climate change communications.
4	06.10.2026	Mental models and framing — Jan Pfänder What are mental models? Which frames are used in climate change communication? How can we frame climate change in a way that allows us to reach different population groups? What are the strategies, channels, and messages used by different stakeholders? 3	[TODO: template lists the climate-delay/denial literature here, which matches session 5's topic — check alignment] Lamb, W. F. et al. (2020). Discourses of climate delay. Cook, J. (2020). Deconstructing Climate Science Denial.
5	13.10.2026	Climate change misinformation — Jan Pfänder What are discourses that delay action on climate change? How do you identify climate science denial and how do you respond to it?	[TODO: template's literature cell held only a guest-prep note — assign readings]

References (draft, to be replaced by references.bib)

[TODO: replace this plain-text list with a Zotero Better BibTeX export to references.bib, then enable nocite/reference-section-title in the front matter and cite with @keys. Leiserowitz et al. (2024) and Corner et al. (2018) are cited above but missing here.]

Barkemeyer, R., Figge, F., Hoepner, A., Holt, D., Kraak, J. M., & Yu, P.-S. (2017). Media coverage of climate change: An international comparison. *Environment and Planning C: Politics and Space*, 35(6), 1029–1054. <https://doi.org/10.1177/0263774X16680818>

Cologna, V., Kotcher, J., Mede, N. G., Besley, J., Maibach, E. W., & Oreskes, N. (2024). Trust in climate science and climate scientists: A narrative review. *PLOS Climate*, 3(5), e0000400. <https://doi.org/10.1371/journal.pclm.0000400>

Cook, J. (2020). Deconstructing climate science denial. In D. C. Holmes & L. M. Richardson (Eds.), *Research Handbook on Communicating Climate Change*. Edward Elgar Publishing. <https://doi.org/10.4337/9781789900408.00014>

Dasandi, N., Graham, H., Hudson, D., Jankin, S., vanHeerde-Hudson, J., & Watts, N. (2022). Positive, global, and health or environment framing bolsters public support for climate policies. *Communications Earth & Environment*, 3(1), 239. <https://doi.org/10.1038/s43247-022-00571-x>

Klinger, K., & Metag, J. (2021). Media Effects in the Context of Environmental Issues. In *The Handbook of International Trends in Environmental Communication*. Routledge.

Lakoff, G. (2010). Why it Matters How We Frame the Environment. *Environmental Communication*, 4(1), 70–81. <https://doi.org/10.1080/17524030903529749>

Lamb, W. F., Mattioli, G., Levi, S., Roberts, J. T., Capstick, S., Creutzig, F., Minx, J. C., Müller-Hansen, F., Culhane, T., & Steinberger, J. K. (2020). Discourses of climate delay. *Global Sustainability*, 3. <https://doi.org/10.1017/sus.2020.13>

Maibach, E. W., Uppalapati, S. S., Orr, M., & Thaker, J. (2023). Harnessing the Power of Communication and Behavior Science to Enhance Society’s Response to Climate Change. *Annual Review of Earth and Planetary Sciences*, 51(1). <https://doi.org/10.1146/annurev-earth-031621-114417>

Markowitz, E. M., & Guckian, M. L. (2018). Climate change communication: Challenges, insights, and opportunities. In S. Clayton & C. Manning (Eds.), *Psychology and Climate Change. Human Perceptions, Impacts, and Responses*. (pp. 35–63). Academic Press. <https://doi.org/10.1016/B978-0-12-813130-5.00003-5>

Metag, J., Fücks, T., & Schäfer, M. S. (2017). Global warming’s five Germanys: A typology of Germans’ views on climate change and patterns of media use and information. *Public Understanding of Science*, 26(4), 434–451. <https://doi.org/10.1177/0963662515592558>

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- Stanley, S. K., Hogg, T. L., Leviston, Z., & Walker, I. (2021). From anger to action: Differential impacts of eco-anxiety, eco-depression, and eco-anger on climate action and wellbeing. *The Journal of Climate Change and Health*, 1, 100003. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.joclim.2021.100003>
- Supran, G., & Oreskes, N. (2021). Rhetoric and frame analysis of ExxonMobil's climate change communications. *One Earth*, 4(5), 696–719. <https://doi.org/10.1016/j.oneear.2021.04.014>